

Bangladesh: an educated approach to women's and children's problems

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She calls it 'the poison within South Asia' — the use of religion or, should I say, the misuse of religion in politics, 'particularly in trying to control women'. The fundamentalists' cry of 'Islam in danger' to further their political ends is an all too familiar one. Women in this region should come together and fight for their rights, says Dr Hameeda Hossain vehemently because she feels that they are going through the same common marginalized treatment from their male counterparts. Born and bred a Pakistani, coming from an affluent Sindhi family, Hameeda looks quite Bengali, complete with the famous *jadoo*.

With traces of grey in her neatly tied-back hair, devoid of any makeup and clad in a black cotton sari, which is slightly crumpled, Hameeda could very well have been a warden in a women's hostel. She never smiles, correction, she does, but that never reaches her eyes. She talks in a soft, controlled voice. She sums up her life by saying, "I've had a fairly chequered history, never followed any one line. I've picked up pieces as I found them interesting". That admission in itself is rather 'interesting, for there are very few people in this world brave enough to do just what they want with their life, spicing up their existence with having flings with inconsistencies. That however, in no way implies that they trivialize life or can't stick to one metier.

To bring home the point forcefully, she asks, "if you look at the election pattern, the *maulvis* don't amount to much, then why do politicians keep bringing up this subject of religion? When you talk to women, or even ordinary people on the street, basically they are just concerned about their basic needs". Unable to make any headway through a democratic process, religious leaders play the religion card to enter the political arena. They have been successful during periods of dictatorship and political stalemate. Treading on dangerous ground, she says forthrightly that there is "an inherent dis-

are not even willing to accept that those heinous crimes even took place."

Once married and living in Dhaka, her perspective was bound to change. She became politically alert. She initially started working for the Oxford University Press and then started a political weekly 'Forum'. The year was 1968. "It was an English weekly and did very well till it lapsed. I wouldn't call it a popular rag but it enjoyed a very influential readership, even in India. It was the voice of the people." The army closed it naturally in 1971 and "Forum breathed" its last.

It was in 1972 that she was exposed, for the first time, to the more 'frontal problems'. These includ-



HAMEEDA HOSSAIN: Open to reality

advantage in religion and now that we're moving towards the 21st century, we shouldn't be clinging to the 14th".

She does not like to be labelled a feminist in the western context. Instead, she would like to see the struggle focus on equality, and justice. And to provide access to justice for the 'disenfranchised' on the basis of gender and ethnicity she, along with a group of people, mostly women, formed a legal aid centre - Ain-o-Salish-Kendra. However, their concentration is more women-oriented "because women are normally much more victimized by different forms of violence and discrimination, particularly legal, and have less access to law". The main complaints of these women relate to marital disputes like polygamy, dowry demand, domestic violence etc. Dr Hameeda and her colleagues normally act as mediators between the two parties because in a lot of cases, there are no documented proofs.

Explaining the objective of her centre, Hameeda says that Ain-o-Salish-Kendra has expanded over the years and includes around eight lawyers. It has a staff strength of around 60 people of whom 20 are men. Apart from legal aid they do legal literacy, human rights education, a lot of public campaigning to create critical awareness of civic and human rights, and legal counselling. She herself not being a lawyer, is in the research and media section.

In these 11 years since they first formed this legal aid centre, Hameeda has felt a massive change in women's awareness. "Women are coming out of their own volition and saying that they can't tolerate so much injustice. Previously, we would go to the slums and get groups together along with other organizations and tell them about their rights."

The latest now in Bangladesh is that a lot of women's groups are talking about uniform family courts - a uniform right for all communities. "We are basically talking across to women's groups and discussing its necessity and to lobby for it with the MPs, the government and various tiers in the government. In the last 15 years or so, there has been a lot of sharing".

It was in the 60s when she had gone to Bangladesh as the bride of a rising young Bengali lawyer, that she had noticed how thwarted the Bengalis were. At that time she confesses she was just an observer, a rather disturbed one at that, for she could see much beyond the veneer. "In those days Bangladesh was involved in a political movement against Ayub Khan, not only against the military rule but for their economic and political rights. All these facets had cultural underpinnings - you know the demand for the language which was being rejected by the establishment". She opines that "I don't think religion is any basis for uniting people when culturally we are so different. The struggle was building up since 1948," and then supporting India's stance she says provocatively, "I think it was a very good idea that we got the support of India. In a way, if this hadn't happened there would've been more massacre. It might've gone on like Vietnam for nine years!"

Coming to the newer generation and whether the wounds of war have healed, Hameeda pounces, ever so stealthily: "the antagonism is still there, it's part of their history so how can they forget that, and anyway has Pakistan asked for forgiveness?" And, then, getting all worked up she goes on, "The leaders, far from apologizing,

ed the atrocities committed on women. "There were massive rape cases, a lot of women were widowed and there was an enormous problem of rehabilitation of the refugees". At the same time, a whole lot of refugees had started pouring in from Calcutta and there was very little by way of skills which they could use for economic sustenance. A lot of these women needed immediate cash for survival. "Their long-term rehabilitation was also on our minds, as to how they were going to bring up their families, and how they were going to earn. For this purpose, we organized the women in groups and formed co-operatives". In a very rudimentary form at that time, the seeds had germinated that would later lead to the formation of the immensely successful Grameen Bank, which has been the widely quoted example of credit provision to the poor.

With economic conditions in Bangladesh still rather fragile, there is still a far greater movement of women over there compared to Pakistan. There is a massive increase of women in the labour force. They also have access to free compulsory education up to the primary level, and for women there is a special arrangement which gives them an advantage in seeking scholarships up to grade 10.

Child labour is a problem in both our countries and Bangladesh has, to some extent, come up with a solution. "A lot of times parents do not let their kids go to school, they want them to work. To overcome that we started drop-in-centres in 1989, for working children". There are five centres like these where children come and go as they like and the ASK makes teachers available whenever the child workers can take time off. The kids' schooling problem is thus solved as they can't access ordinary schools. They work and they also come in their free time. In one drop-in centre there are 500 children. This however, does not mean that they go there every day. "They come to play, sleep or study, but most of all, they bring in their problems - many say how upset parents get when they do not bring in money".

A few years ago in the US, there was active campaigning against Child Labour and a Bill was being introduced. This meant that the US would put a ban on import of goods made by children. Hameeda thinks if that had been introduced, it would have gone against the interest of the working children. "We did lobbying for this to show that if the children dropped out of work, they would lose out because they would be going to worse occupations and become poorer".

An arrangement which is backed by UNICEF and ILO was reached. In this respect, the garment manufacturers have said that they would not employ children under 14 years and for the ones already in their employment, they would have schools opened for them run by NGOs. A stipend of 300 Takas is given so that parents are compensated for the money the children were earning.

Hameeda, however, does not feel that it is the most perfect model as the children still want to work. "What we had suggested was to let these kids work, but to reduce the number of hours and let them study as well". Her gripe is that when the North talks about human rights and child rights, they forget that it's some of their policies like the Structural Adjustment Programme that the World bank and IMF keep introducing which has led to poverty and unemployment". ■